



For Staff

Controlling and Coercive Behaviour Between Young People

Recognising and responding when one young person controls another, in a relationship, a friendship or a group

Content Warning This guide covers controlling relationships, threats and abuse.

This is reference guidance, not a training course. Use it to check how to respond, or to prepare for a conversation. It does not replace the school's safeguarding training, policy or the DSL's advice on a specific case.

It contains descriptions of controlling and coercive behaviour, threats (including threats of self-harm and image-based abuse), and honour-based abuse. Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or that of someone close to you.

- You can read it in sections, take a break, or step away at any point.
- If this raises something personal, you can speak in confidence to your line manager, a senior colleague you trust, or the school's Employee Assistance Programme, if it has one, or **Education Support** (free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561). The **National Domestic Abuse Helpline** is free and open 24 hours on 0808 2000 247.
- If you have a question about how this guidance applies to a situation you are dealing with, speak to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

If reading this makes you worried about a child now, do not wait until you have finished reading: speak to the DSL or a deputy straight away. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response. **Go to the Quick Reference Card.**

Why This Matters

Controlling behaviour is common in teenage relationships and is not confined to adults. In a 2025 survey of more than 10,000 13 to 17 year olds in England and Wales, **more than a third of those who had been in a relationship had experienced emotionally abusive or controlling behaviour** ([Youth Endowment Fund, 2025](#)).

KCSIE 2026 lists abuse in intimate personal relationships between children ("teenage relationship abuse") as a form of child-on-child abuse (paragraph 37), and expects preventative education to cover how to recognise and report an abusive relationship, including coercive and controlling behaviour (paragraph 160). Control also happens in friendships and groups, where the law on domestic abuse does not apply but the safeguarding response does.

Scenario Overview

A Year 10 student controls what another student does: who they talk to, what they wear, where they go and who they message. It might be a relationship, a friendship, or a group.

What to Keep in Mind

- It is usually a **pattern over time**, and it may look like closeness, care or jealousy. **A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you do not need to wait for it to happen again before reporting a concern.** A single threat, physical restriction, sexual coercion or image-based blackmail needs action straight away.
- It can happen in **romantic relationships, friendships, clubs, teams and groups**, same-sex or mixed, in person and online.
- **Digital control** is likely: constant messaging, phone checks, location sharing, password demands, threats about images.
- Both students may have come to see it as normal. The student being controlled may defend the other student.
- Girls and boys both experience it: in the 2025 survey, 41% of girls and 37% of boys who had been in a relationship had experienced emotional or physical abuse (YEF, 2025).
- **Both students are usually children** and both need a safeguarding response. Accountability and support go together. Where a student is 18, see the note for the DSL under Notify.

How RESPOND Works in This Scenario

RESPOND is powered by **ACT**: **Active Intervention** (inaction is not neutral), **Contextual Safeguarding** (control often runs through peer groups, group chats and shared spaces) and **Trauma-Informed Practice** (safety before emotion before thinking). The steps are taught in order but work as a **helix**: see *The RESPOND Helix* section.

Step	RESPOND tool	In this scenario
● Recognise	4 Ps Context Scan; Escalation of Unseen Harm	Look for the pattern: isolation, monitoring, fear
● Engage	TED questions; 4Ds of Active Intervention	Listen without labelling; step in if you witness control, if it is safe to do so
● Support	Safety check first; "Your calm is contagious"	Physical, emotional and digital safety, today
● Pause	90-second grounding; Three Lenses (Risk, Rights, Resources)	Don't confront, don't mediate, don't investigate
● Offer	Model alternatives; if in doubt, N before O	What healthy looks like; options, not orders
● Notify	DSL, as soon as is practicably possible	Same day. You don't need certainty
● Document	GOLD standard	Their exact words and the specific behaviours

Need the essentials? The *Quick Reference Card* at the end of this guide covers the immediate response and escalation on one page.

The One Chance Rule: a disclosure may be a young person's only attempt to seek help. Make it count.



The RESPOND Helix: How the Steps Move

RESPOND is taught in a line, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. In practice it moves as a helix. The first dimension is the steps themselves: you may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. The second is time and severity: each turn sits higher as a concern develops. The third is context: a concern involving several children, places or platforms traces a wider spiral.

Relational and Systemic

For a child, safeguarding is **relational**: it happens through people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: the steps, records and shared decisions that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help.

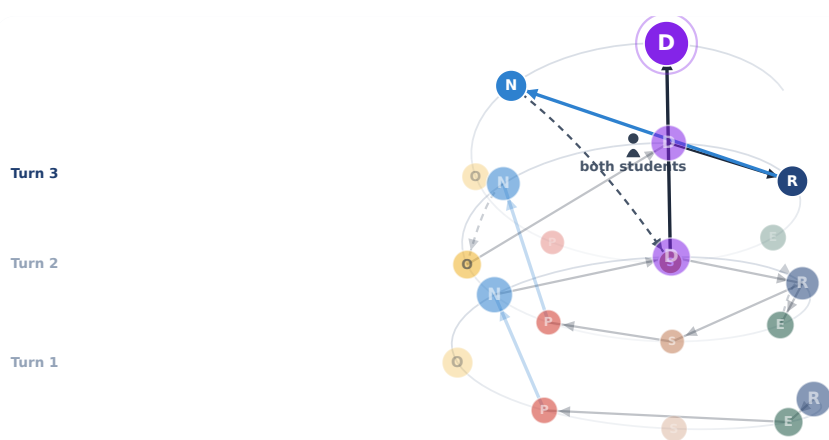
Relational is why children tell. Systemic is why telling works.

The RESPOND steps follow the same shape: Recognise, Engage and Support are relational; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps. Neither works alone. Relationship without the system becomes secrecy, which is why staff never promise to keep a disclosure to themselves. The system without relationship becomes process that children do not trust enough to use. When you share information, be open with the child about what you are sharing and why.

See It Move

Two examples: a teenage relationship and a controlling friendship. Then see a wider spiral, where friends are involved, and what happens when steps are skipped.

This is a still image of the interactive RESPOND Helix. Open the web version of this guide to step through the examples; every example is also written out in full below.



▼ Read the helix demonstration as text

Sequence

How RESPOND is taught.

1. **The seven steps:** RESPOND is taught in this order, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. Recognise, Engage and Support are the relational steps; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps.
2. **But practice is not a line:** Coercive control is a pattern, so it rarely shows itself in one moment. You may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. Choose an example to see how the steps move.

A teenage relationship

A Year 10 student whose partner controls who they see, what they wear and where they are, over a term. Both are children: the helix wraps around both of them.

1. **Turn 1: a friend is worried:** A student tells their tutor that a friend's partner "won't let them talk to anyone else" and makes them text constantly. Recognise: one report, from a friend, about a pattern. Use the 4 Ps.
2. **Turn 1:** Engage with the friend who told you: thank them, and use TED. "Tell me what you've noticed." Don't ask them to find out more.
3. **Turn 1:** Pause: no immediate risk is known. Do not speak to either student in the relationship yet, and don't confront the partner: that could make things worse for the student being controlled.
4. **Turn 1:** Notify: tell the DSL the same day. A friend's worry is often the first sign; the DSL decides who speaks to whom.
5. **Turn 1:** Document: GOLD, with the friend's exact words and what you did.
6. **Turn 2: a pattern (two weeks later):** A teacher notices the student has dropped dance club, dresses differently, and looks anxious whenever their phone buzzes. Because the first concern was recorded, the DSL can link them.
7. **Turn 2:** Engage: a trusted adult checks in privately. The student says their partner checks their phone every day and gets angry if they talk to anyone. Use the script: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."
8. **Turn 2: loop back:** Loop back to Recognise: isolation, monitoring and fear together are the pattern of coercive control, not a relationship problem.
9. **Turn 2:** Support: ask about physical, emotional and digital safety, and about today: breaks, lunch, the journey home. Agree phone and location changes with them; sudden cut-offs can raise the risk.
10. **Turn 2:** Pause: 90 seconds, then Three Lenses. Don't investigate, don't promise secrecy, and never suggest mediation: this is abuse, not a disagreement.
1. **Turn 2: N before O:** Notify before Offer: the DSL, as soon as is practicably possible, and today. The DSL plans the response for both students, including when and how parents are told.
2. **Turn 2:** Offer, once the DSL has decided: model alternatives. What a healthy relationship looks like; options for support; a say in the safety plan.
3. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD, with their exact words and the specific controlling behaviours described.
4. **Turn 3: risk:** The student tells you their partner has said they will hurt themselves if the relationship ends, and has threatened to share a private image.
5. **Turn 3: straight to Notify:** Go straight from Recognise to Notify: the DSL, immediately. There is a risk to both students. Don't ask to see any image.
6. **Turn 3:** Support: stay with the student, and don't let them leave with the other student while the DSL acts. You never leave a step behind.
7. **Turn 3:** Document: GOLD, as soon as is practicably possible: what they said about both threats, in their words.

A controlling friendship

A Year 8 student whose closest friend decides who she sits with and what she does. Control happens in friendships too, and it can start young.

1. **Turn 1: "just a falling-out"?:** Other students say they have been "warned off" talking to a Year 8 girl by her best friend, who decides where she sits and who she talks to. Recognise: look at People and Patterns, not one incident.
2. **Turn 1:** Engage: a quiet, kind check-in with the girl. TED: "Tell me how things are with your friends at the moment."
3. **Turn 1:** Support: she says everything is fine. Keep the door open and tell her she can come back to you at any time.
4. **Turn 1:** Notify: pass it to the DSL through the school's usual system. Patterns in friendships are only visible when concerns are shared.
5. **Turn 1:** Document: GOLD, with what other students said and what you saw.
6. **Turn 2: a pattern (a month later):** She has stopped going to her club and says her friend "gets upset" if she replies to anyone else. Her friend reads her messages at break.
7. **Turn 2:** Engage: she tells you she is scared of losing her only friend. Listen without criticising the friend.
8. **Turn 2: loop back:** Loop back to Recognise: isolation and monitoring make this controlling behaviour, not an ordinary friendship problem.
9. **Turn 2:** Pause: both are children. The friend may be anxious or struggling too; that shapes the support, not whether the behaviour is addressed.
10. **Turn 2:** Notify: the DSL, as soon as is practicably possible. The DSL decides how each student and their parents are approached.
1. **Turn 2:** Offer: model alternatives. Help her rebuild other friendships gradually; pastoral work with the friend on healthy friendships and managing worry.
2. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD, with dates, so the pattern stays visible.

Wider spiral

Controlling behaviour is often encouraged by friends. One relationship, several people involved.

1. **Three strands:** A Year 11 student's partner checks their location all day, and the partner's friends message to report where the student has been. A single concern traces a tight spiral; this one is wider.
2. **At the same time:** Support the student being controlled; pause before any contact with the partner, whom the DSL will plan for. The friends' role is still being recognised.
3. **At the same time:** The partner and the group's part both go to the DSL. Don't speak to the friends yourself: that can alert the partner.
4. **Joined up:** Notify: one joined-up picture for the DSL. Offer, once the DSL has decided: education and accountability for the partner; friends shown how not to join in, and how to speak up if it is safe to do so.
5. **Every strand:** Every strand ends in Document. Friends' involvement is part of the pattern and belongs in the record.

When it breaks

The same Year 10 relationship, when steps are skipped.

1. **Turn 1:** A friend reports that the student's partner won't let them talk to anyone. Recognise happens.
2. **Pause skipped:** The adult calls it "teen drama" and speaks to the partner directly: "leave them alone". Pause is skipped, and the partner now knows someone has told.

3. **Document skipped:** Nothing is recorded. When a teacher later notices the student has dropped their club, there is nothing to connect it to.
4. **Notify skipped:** The concern stays with one adult. Professionals working in isolation, and information not being shared, are recurring findings in serious case reviews.
5. **The helix fragments:** The control tightens. The student has learned that telling makes it worse, and stops telling. That is how harm escalates unseen.
6. **Put it back together:** Every step taken puts the structure back. Relational is why children tell; systemic is why telling works.

The Helix is described in the RESPOND Safeguarding Operating System (section 5.2). All examples are fictional.

R

RECOGNISE: Identify the Pattern

Coercive control is a pattern of behaviour that makes someone dependent, isolated or afraid. The pattern helps you understand it, but it is not a threshold: report a single serious incident straight away. You don't need certainty to act.

The 4 Ps Context Scan

People

Who is involved? A partner, a best friend, a friendship group? Who has the power, and who is being cut off?

Places

Where does it happen?
Breaks, lunch, corridors, the journey home, clubs, the boarding house

Platforms

Messages, location sharing, social media, gaming, shared passwords, image threats

Patterns

Is it repeated? Getting worse? Are friends joining in? Has the student dropped activities or friends?

What Controlling Behaviour Looks Like Between Young People

Isolation

- Deciding who the other student can talk to, sit with or be friends with
- Getting angry or upset when they spend time with others

- Making them choose between the controller and other friends or family
- Spreading rumours about people who stay friends with them

Monitoring

- Constant messaging and demanding instant replies
- Checking their phone, messages or social media
- Requiring location sharing at all times, or getting friends to report back
- Demanding passwords, or logging into their accounts

Rules About Appearance and Behaviour

- Telling them what to wear, or criticising how they look
- Controlling which clubs, activities or events they go to
- Setting "rules" and punishing them for breaking them
- Using culture, faith or "honour" to justify restrictions or shame

Manipulation and Threats

- Guilt: "If you cared about me, you'd..."
- Threatening to end the relationship or friendship, or to self-harm, if they don't comply
- Threatening to share private images or secrets
- Humiliating them, or making them doubt their own memory (gaslighting)
- Blaming them for the controlling behaviour

Signs in the Student Being Controlled

- Withdrawn from friends or activities they used to enjoy
- Anxious about their phone, or checking it constantly
- Changed appearance, or asking permission before making plans

- Fearful of the other student, or unable to speak freely when they are there
- Making excuses for the other student's behaviour
- Falling attendance, attainment or concentration

Signs in the Student Showing Controlling Behaviour

- Jealousy or possessiveness presented as care
- Constant monitoring; speaking for the other student or interrupting them
- Anger when questioned, and minimising or justifying the behaviour
- Charming with adults and different with peers

Some young people who control others have experienced harm or control themselves. That shapes the support they need; it does not reduce the safeguarding response or the risk to the other student.

No Disclosure Needed

Many young people will not describe what is happening as abuse, and some will defend the other student. If you notice isolation, monitoring or fear, pass it to the DSL **without waiting for a disclosure**. Record what you saw and heard, factually.

What the Law Says (England and Wales)

- **All ages:** controlling behaviour between children is a safeguarding concern and may be child-on-child abuse. KCSIE 2026 lists abuse in intimate personal relationships between children as child-on-child abuse (paragraph 37).
- **The definition of domestic abuse** applies where both people are **16 or over** and "personally connected": current or former partners and people in an intimate personal relationship, whether or not they live together, and family members. It does **not** include friends. Under that definition, domestic abuse can be a single incident or a course of conduct (Domestic Abuse Act 2021, section 1; section 2).
- **The criminal offence is separate from the definition.** Controlling or coercive behaviour is an offence between people who are personally connected where the behaviour is **repeated or continuous**, has a **serious effect** (fear of violence on at least two occasions, or serious alarm or distress that has a substantial adverse effect on day-to-day activities), and the person **knows or ought to know** it will have that effect. It carries up to five years (Serious Crime Act 2015, section 76; CPS guidance). It has no minimum age of 16, apart from an exception where the person has parental responsibility for a child under 16. Criminal responsibility in England and Wales begins at 10 (GOV.UK).
- **Younger children, and friendships:** the behaviour remains a safeguarding concern and may be child-on-child abuse. Criminal offences may also apply, depending on the conduct, the ages and relationship of those involved, and the circumstances.

- **Working Together 2026** notes that 16 and 17 year olds can be victims of controlling or coercive behaviour in their own relationships (Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026).

Staff should not decide whether an offence has been committed. Report the concern to the DSL. Legal references checked September 2026.

What the Data Shows



The Youth Endowment Fund surveyed 10,835 13 to 17 year olds in England and Wales between May and July 2025. Police figures cover all ages and mostly adults; they show the offence is recognised and increasingly recorded, not how common it is among young people. Checked September 2026.

E

ENGAGE: Listen Without Labelling

Respond with calm, open listening. Use TED questions, never "why". Let the young person describe it in their own words before anyone calls it abuse.

If a Friend Tells You

"I'm really worried about my friend. Their partner won't let them talk to anyone else. They have to text all the time, and they get told what to wear."

- **Thank them:** "Thank you for telling me. Looking out for a friend like that takes courage."

- **TED:** "Tell me what you've noticed." "Explain how long it's been like this." "Describe how your friend seems."
- **Don't ask them to find out more**, confront anyone, or keep watch. Tell them you will pass it on and that it was right to tell you.
- Check how **they** are: worrying about a friend is heavy to carry.

If the Student Tells You Directly

"My girlfriend gets really angry if I talk to my other friends and checks my phone all the time. I feel like I can't do anything without asking her first."

The RESPOND disclosure script:

"I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."

- **TED:** "Tell me more about what's been happening." "Explain what happens when you don't reply." "Describe how you feel when you're with them."
- "Do you feel safe right now?" "Who else knows?"
- Use their words. If you are not quoting, use neutral words such as "partner" or "friend", and don't assume anyone's gender or sexuality.
- Validate: "That sounds exhausting." "Healthy relationships involve trust and freedom, not constant checking."
- Don't rush to call it "abuse"; that can make them defend the other student and stop talking.

Helpful

- "What would make this feel safer for you right now?"
- "You're not responsible for someone else's behaviour."
- Reflect back: "So it sounds like you feel you can't..."
- Minimal encouragers: "Go on." "I'm listening."

Unhelpful

- "Why don't you just end it?" (judgemental, and ending it can be the most dangerous time)
- "That doesn't sound that bad." "Are you sure?" (minimising)
- "They must really care about you." (confuses love with control)
- "Just block them." (oversimplifies, and can escalate)
- "I'll have a word with them." (could put the student at greater risk)

- "What did you do to make them act like that?" (blame)

If You Witness Controlling Behaviour

If you see one student grabbing another's phone, blocking them from leaving, or publicly humiliating them, act **if it is safe to do so**, using the 4Ds: **Direct** ("Give that back, please"), **Distract** (give the student a reason to come with you), **Delegate** (get a colleague), **Delay** (check in privately afterwards). Deal with the moment; don't challenge the relationship in front of others. Then pass it to the DSL.

S SUPPORT: Safety First

Your first job is safety today: physical, emotional and digital. Your calm is contagious.

Safety Check Questions

Physical

- "Has there ever been any physical violence, or threats?"
- "Are you worried about what might happen when you leave here today?"

Emotional

- "How are you feeling right now?"
- "Do you feel able to go to your next lesson?"

Digital

- "Do they have your passwords, or track your location?"

- "Are you worried about them finding out you've spoken to me?"

Today

- "What happens at break and lunch?" "Do you travel home together?"
- "Are they expecting to hear from you?"

Digital Safety Planning

Agree any changes to phone use, location sharing and passwords **with** the student and the DSL. A sudden cut-off can alert the other student and raise the risk. Plan changes in steps (for example, turning off location sharing once timetable changes are in place) and record the reasons.

Immediate Support

- A private, quiet space; time; water; the option to stay rather than go straight to a lesson
- "You've done the right thing by telling me. This is not your fault."
- "You're not on your own with this. There are people who can help."

SEND, Neurodivergence and Language

- Allow extra processing time and a quiet space. Use clear, concrete language; avoid idioms and double questions.
- Offer visual or written ways to communicate. Some students may find it harder to recognise control, or may be targeted because of it.
- Use a professional interpreter where language is a barrier, never another student or a family member.
- Record any adjustments you made.

Protective Options to Discuss With the DSL

- A different route between lessons, or someone with them at break and lunch
- Changes to groups or seating
- Timetable changes, where the student wants them

- Where arrangements change, **avoid placing the burden on the student being controlled**. The DSL decides; don't separate students on your own initiative.

Both Students Need Support

The student showing controlling behaviour is a child too. Some have experienced harm or adversity themselves. Support combines **clear boundaries and accountability** with the chance to learn safer ways of relating. That context informs support planning; it never reduces the safety plan for the other student.

For the Student Being Controlled

- Safety planning, including online
- Rebuilding confidence and friendships
- Understanding healthy relationships
- Mental health support if needed

For the Student Showing the Behaviour

- Understanding why the behaviour is harmful
- Learning about healthy relationships and managing jealousy and anger
- Exploring what may sit behind it, including their own experiences
- Accountability without shaming



PAUSE: Consider Your Approach

Act with composure. The Pause creates space between the disclosure and your response. Take 90 seconds: breathe, lower your shoulders, check your own state.

Three Lenses

Lens	In this scenario
Risk	Is there violence, a threat (including to self-harm), an image threat, or a risk the other student will find out today?
Rights	The student's right to be safe, to be heard, and to have a say in the plan; the other student's rights as a child too
Resources	The DSL, pastoral and counselling staff, the school nurse, specialist services, and safe adults in the student's life

What You Must Not Do

Don't Investigate

- Don't interview other students or check social media to "gather evidence"
- Ask only what you need for immediate safety and basic facts
- Curiosity is not neutral: it can drift into investigation

Don't Confront the Other Student

- Don't warn them to "leave them alone" or ask for "their side"
- It can escalate the control and put the student at greater risk
- The DSL plans any contact

Don't Promise Secrecy

"I'm really glad you've told me. I can't keep this completely to myself, because I'm worried about your safety. I'll need to speak to the DSL, whose job is to get you the right support. I'll only share it with people who need to know, and I'll tell you what's happening at each step."

Don't Try to Fix the Relationship

- No mediation, "talking it through together" or couples-style conversations
- This is abuse, not a disagreement
- Don't push the student to end it: that decision, and its timing, needs a safety plan

Don't Minimise Because They're Young

- Teenage relationships matter, and their impact is real
- Patterns of control learned young can continue into adulthood
- This is safeguarding, not "teen drama"

Check Your Own Response

- Notice your reactions: anger at one student, frustration with the other for "not just leaving"
- Avoid the rescuer mindset: the student needs choice and support, not someone taking over
- Be aware of how your own relationship experiences may shape your response
- If you feel overwhelmed: "This is important and I want to get it right. Can you wait here for a few minutes while I speak to the DSL?"



OFFER: Model Alternatives

Offer proportionate options without coercion, explain what happens next, and model what a healthy relationship or friendship looks like. If in doubt, N before O: tell the DSL before offering options.

Explain What Happens Next

"Here's what happens now. I'm going to speak to our safeguarding lead, whose job is to make sure you're safe and get the right support. They'll probably want to talk to you today, and I can be there if you'd like. Because you're under 18, your parents or carers will usually need to know; we'll talk with you about how and when. We'll work out a plan with you for school, like breaks, routes and

who you can go to. This isn't about getting anyone into trouble; it's about keeping you safe. What questions do you have?"

Be honest about information sharing. Staff should share safeguarding information as early as possible, and data protection law does not prevent it; safeguarding children is a lawful basis for sharing sensitive information without consent where appropriate (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 142 to 148). What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. From 30 September 2026, the Information Sharing Duty (section 16LA, Children Act 2004) also requires the organisations it covers to share where its tests are met; the DSL decides how it applies. So don't ask for consent as if it were the legal basis. Tell the student what will be shared, with whom and why, unless that would increase the risk, and listen to their views: they shape the plan. Agreeing to a service, such as counselling, is a separate question, and their agreement matters there.

Options, Not Orders

- "When would you feel most comfortable talking to the DSL: now, or later today?"
- "Would you like me there?"
- "How would you like your parents to be told: with you there, or with us leading?"
- "What would make you feel safer at school right now?"

Some things have to happen to keep them safe. Where there is a choice, give it to them.

Model the Alternative

Healthy

- Trust, and time with other friends
- Privacy, including your phone
- Disagreeing without fear
- Being yourself, and wearing what you choose

Controlling

- Deciding who you see
- Checking your phone or location
- Fear of their reaction

- Rules about how you look or act

Use the student's own words to reflect the difference. Healthy relationships education belongs in the curriculum for everyone, not only for the students involved.

Support in School and Beyond

- Counselling or pastoral mentoring; a daily check-in with a trusted adult
- The tutor made aware (without details) so they can support
- A friend with them at breaks, if they want that
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Love Respect (Women's Aid): loverspect.co.uk, information and a relationship quiz for young people
- Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111

What Support Looks Like Over Time

When	Focus	What it includes
Short term	Safety	School safety plan, daily check-ins, parental involvement as planned by the DSL, counselling access, any agreed separation
Medium term	Both students	Therapeutic or specialist support, work on healthy relationships, monitoring and review of the plan
Longer term	Recovery	Rebuilding friendships and confidence, academic support, relationships education, continued review

N NOTIFY: Report the Concern

Tell the DSL as soon as is practicably possible, and the same day. You don't need certainty: you need to share your concern. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Who and When

- Find the DSL in person if you can: "I need to speak to you today about a safeguarding concern involving controlling behaviour between students."
- If the DSL is not available, go to a deputy. If neither can be reached and there is immediate risk, go to a senior leader. Don't wait until the end of the day.
- Anyone can refer directly to children's social care if they believe a child is at risk; telling the DSL does not remove your own responsibility.

What to Tell the DSL

- Who told you, or what you saw, and when
- The specific controlling behaviours described (who they can see, what they wear, phone and location checks)
- How long it has been going on, if known
- Any violence, threats (including threats to self-harm), or image threats
- Digital control, and whether the other student may know they have told
- How the student feels, whether they feel safe now, and where they are
- What you have said and done so far

▼ For the DSL: assessment, external agencies and parents

Most staff need only: tell the DSL, today, with the information above.

The DSL's Initial Actions

- Assess immediate risk to **both** students, including self-harm and image threats, and any other students involved or affected
- Agree a safety plan, including any separation, routes, breaks and online steps, without placing the burden on the student being controlled
- Decide who speaks to each student, when, and how; plan any contact with the student showing controlling behaviour so it does not increase risk
- Consider whether either student is experiencing harm at home
- Where the Information Sharing Duty applies (from 30 September 2026), apply its three tests: share information that is relevant to safeguarding or promoting the child's welfare (Relevance) and may help the recipient to safeguard or promote their welfare (May facilitate), unless sharing would be more detrimental to the child than not sharing (Detriment), which applies only in extremely limited circumstances; record the decision to share or not share, with the rationale, and be transparent with the young person
- Record on the safeguarding system, with a chronology

When to Involve Other Agencies

Agency	When
Children's social care	Significant harm or risk of it to either student; harm at home; concerns about parents' ability to keep a child safe
Police	Violence, threats, stalking, harassment or image offences; where the behaviour between partners, ex-partners or family members may meet the controlling or coercive behaviour offence; any serious risk
Specialist domestic abuse services	Advice on risk and support for the young person, and for work with the student showing the behaviour (for example, Respect Young People's Service)
Mental health services	Mental health crisis, or where either student needs assessment or therapeutic support

Where a Student Is 18

At 18 a student is legally an adult. The child safeguarding framework in KCSIE applies to under-18s, but the school still has welfare responsibilities. Where an 18-year-old is involved, as the person affected or the person showing the behaviour, the DSL considers adult safeguarding, domestic abuse, police and welfare pathways alongside the school's procedures, and the adult student's own views and consent in a different way. This matters in sixth form and in boarding, where students turn 18 during their final year.

Before Contacting Parents or Carers

Assess whether telling parents could increase the risk: for example, if controlling behaviour is reinforced at home, or honour-based abuse or forced marriage is a possibility. Where it could, seek advice from children's social care or the police first and agree a safe plan.

Parent contact: the student being controlled

- "We need to talk to you about [name]. They've told us about a situation with another student that's worrying them."
- "[Name] has described controlling behaviour in a [friendship/relationship], including [specific examples, without excessive detail]."
- "We're treating this as a safeguarding matter and want to work with you. How has [name] seemed at home?"

Parent contact: the student showing controlling behaviour

- "We need to talk to you about [name]'s behaviour towards another student."
- "We've become aware that [name] has been [specific behaviours]. This is a safeguarding concern and needs to stop."
- "We're also concerned about [name]'s wellbeing, and want to understand what might be going on for them and make sure they get support."

D DOCUMENT: Record Observations

Record as soon as is practicably possible, on the school's safeguarding system, using **GOLD**. Your record may be used by other agencies.

GOLD

Ground

Date, time, place, who was present, who you are, and how it came to your attention

Observe

What you saw and heard, with exact words in quotation marks

Language

Neutral, factual and non-diagnostic. No opinions about either student or the relationship

Do

What you did, what you said would happen next, and why

Example: Exact Words and Specific Behaviours

- Student said: "They check my phone every day and get angry if I've talked to anyone."
- Student said: "If I don't reply in five minutes they say I'm cheating."
- Student said: "They said they'd hurt themselves if I left."
- Observed: tearful, checked phone repeatedly during the conversation; said they had stopped going to dance club
- Specific behaviours described: location shared at all times; told not to wear certain clothes; not allowed to speak to certain friends; social media likes and follows checked

Recording template

SAFEGUARDING CONCERN: CONTROLLING BEHAVIOUR BETWEEN STUDENTS

Date and time:

Student concerned (being controlled): name, year, tutor group

Other student: name, year, tutor group

Recorded by: name and role

Where and how it came to your attention:

WHAT WAS SAID (exact words in quotation marks):

SPECIFIC CONTROLLING BEHAVIOURS DESCRIBED OR SEEN:

HOW LONG IT HAS BEEN HAPPENING:

OBSERVATIONS (presentation, emotional state):

SAFETY: physical / emotional / digital / immediate risks

WHAT I DID AND SAID (with times):

SHARED WITH: DSL (name, time, how)

THE STUDENT'S WISHES:

Signed and dated:

What Not to Record

- Personal opinions about either student, or about the relationship
- Assumptions about families, culture or causes
- Speculation, or comments about character
- Content of any intimate image. Describe what you were told; never copy or describe the image

Online and Digital Control

For many young people, control happens mainly through their phone. It follows them home, into the evening and into the boarding house.

What It Can Look Like

- Location sharing that cannot be turned off, or friends asked to report back
- Demands for passwords, or logging into the other student's accounts
- Hundreds of messages a day, and anger at slow replies
- Rules about who they follow, like or message
- Threats to share private images or messages

What Staff Do

- Pass it to the DSL; don't look through the student's phone yourself
- Plan any changes to phone, location or passwords **with** the student and the DSL
- If intimate images are involved, follow the UKCIS nudes and semi-nudes guidance: don't view, copy, forward or delete; secure the device if needed; tell the DSL immediately
- Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation) helps under-18s get nude images of themselves removed online

Boarding and Residential Life

For boarders, school is also home. Control does not stop at the end of the day, and a student may be living alongside the person controlling them.

Step	In boarding
● Recognise	Use the 4 Ps for the house: who shares rooms, tables and prep; evenings, weekends and exeats; house group chats and phones after lights out. Notice changes at meals, bedtime and sleep.
● Engage	Houseparents often hear things first, at informal times. Use TED. Talk in a visible space with the door open, and let another adult know.
● Support	Safety tonight comes first: where will they sleep, who is on duty, and how do they reach night staff? Changes to rooms, tables or prep should not fall on the student being controlled unless they ask for them.
● Pause	Consider the whole house. If both students board, the control may continue all evening. Do not investigate or promise secrecy. If there is immediate risk, do not wait until morning.
● Offer	Model alternatives: house expectations about privacy, phones and relationships; older boarders as positive role models. If in doubt, N before O.
● Notify	Contact the on-call DSL or boarding deputy DSL straight away where there is risk. If a child is in immediate danger and no DSL can be reached, call 999; out of hours, contact the local authority's emergency duty team.

Step

In boarding

- Record on the safeguarding system before you go off duty, using GOLD. A house log or handover note is not a substitute.

Document

Boarders' Routes to Help

- **Boarders can always contact their house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.** Make sure every boarder knows how.
- An independent person outside the staff whom boarders can contact directly (NMS 11.4), often called the independent listener
- Boarders must be able to contact their families privately; monitoring of communications should be proportionate (NMS 12.1)
- International boarders: agree with the DSL who contacts parents or guardians, when, and in what language, using interpreters where needed

Source: National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026).

Identity and Intersecting Harm

- **LGBTQ+ young people** may face control through threats to "out" them, and may find it harder to tell anyone. Don't assume the genders of those involved. For under-18s: Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111. For those 18 and over: Galop National LGBTQ+ Domestic Abuse Helpline (18 and over): 0800 999 5428 (Monday and Tuesday 9:15am to 8pm, Wednesday to Friday 9:15am to 4:30pm).
- **Culture, faith and "honour"**: restrictions justified by culture, faith or family honour can be controlling behaviour, and may point to honour-based abuse or forced marriage. Treat it as a safeguarding concern, not a cultural matter, and pass it to the DSL straight away. Don't contact the family first. Forced Marriage Unit: 020 7008 0151, fmf@fcdo.gov.uk. Karma Nirvana (honour-based abuse and forced marriage): 0800 5999 247 (Monday to Friday 9am to 5pm).
- **Boys experience control too**, and may be less likely to recognise or report it. Girls controlling boys, and control in same-sex relationships, need the same response.
- **SEND and neurodivergent students** may find it harder to recognise control or to say no, and may be targeted because of it. Some may control others without understanding the impact; the behaviour still needs addressing.

- **Race and stereotypes** can affect who is seen as a victim and who is believed. Check whether assumptions about any student are shaping your response.

Additional Resources and Support

For Students

- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at childline.org.uk (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Love Respect (Women's Aid): loverespect.co.uk, information and a relationship quiz for young people
- Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111
- Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): nude images of under-18s removed online

For Parents and Carers

- National Domestic Abuse Helpline (Refuge): 0808 2000 247, free, 24 hours
- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- YoungMinds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- Respect Phoneline: 0808 802 4040 (Monday to Friday 10am to 5pm), for anyone worried about their own behaviour in a relationship

For Staff

- Childline, *Healthy and unhealthy relationships*
- SafeLives, *Spotlight: young people and domestic abuse*
- Respect Young People's Service: respectyps.org.uk, for professionals working with 8 to 18 year olds who use harm in close relationships

- Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff
- Home Office, *Controlling or coercive behaviour: statutory guidance framework*

Statutory Guidance and Law

- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*
- HM Government, *Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026*
- Department for Education, *Information Sharing Duty: statutory guidance* (in force 30 September 2026)
- Department for Education, *RSHE statutory guidance* (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026)
- Department for Education, *National minimum standards for boarding schools* (2026)
- UKCIS, *Sharing nudes and semi-nudes: advice for education settings*
- Domestic Abuse Act 2021, section 1 (definition of domestic abuse)
- Domestic Abuse Act 2021, section 2 ("personally connected")
- Serious Crime Act 2015, section 76 (controlling or coercive behaviour)
- Crown Prosecution Service, *Controlling or coercive behaviour in an intimate or family relationship*

Figures

- Youth Endowment Fund, *Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2025: violence in relationships* (survey of 10,835 13 to 17 year olds, May to July 2025)
- Youth Endowment Fund, *One in every classroom* (December 2025)
- Office for National Statistics, *Domestic abuse prevalence and trends, England and Wales: year ending March 2025*

Contacts, figures and legal references checked 28 September 2026. Verify at point of use.

Quick Reference Card

Immediate Danger Comes First

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response.

Recognise

- One student controlling another's friendships, appearance, phone or movements
- Isolation, anxiety, constant phone checking

- Dropped activities or friends
- No disclosure needed, and no need to wait for a pattern if there is a threat

Respond

- "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- TED, never "why"
- Don't promise secrecy
- Don't confront the other student or mediate

Notify

- DSL, as soon as is practicably possible, the same day
- Immediate danger: 999
- If in doubt, N before O
- Both students need a safeguarding response

Document

- GOLD: Ground, Observe, Language, Do
- Exact words and specific behaviours
- No opinions, and never describe an image

Key Numbers

- Emergency: 999; police non-emergency: 101
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- National Domestic Abuse Helpline (Refuge, for adults): 0808 2000 247, free, 24 hours
- Your DSL: named in the school's safeguarding policy

Online Evidence: One Rule

- **Ordinary messages or posts a student has already shown you:** note what is relevant (platform, date, who, exact words) in your record. Don't ask to see more or scroll through a phone, especially where messages may be sexual, because they may contain images. Don't log in to accounts, search profiles or investigate, and never transfer anything to a personal device.
- **Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18:** don't intentionally view, copy, screenshot, forward, save or delete them. Tell the DSL straight away. If you see one by accident, tell the DSL, ask for support if you need it, and record that it was seen and what you did, without describing the image (UKCIS).
- The DSL decides what happens to devices and content.

Your School's Contacts

This guide is generic. Schools add their own details here, or keep a completed copy with this card, so that anyone responding, including at night, has the routes to hand.

Contact	Name and how to reach them
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	
Deputy DSL(s)	
Out-of-hours and boarding on-call safeguarding contact	
How to record a concern (system or form)	
Local authority children's services front door	
Out-of-hours emergency duty team	
LADO (concerns about adults)	
Police: 999 (emergency); 101 (non-emergency)	

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Reference Scenarios · Staff Guide 46

Scenario 46: Controlling and Coercive Behaviour Between Young People

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Aligned with: KCSIE 2026 | Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 | Information Sharing Duty (September 2026) | Domestic Abuse Act 2021 | RSHE statutory guidance (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026) | NMS for Boarding Schools 2026

Last Updated: September 2026 | Next Review: September 2027, or on publication of KCSIE 2027 if sooner

For staff in schools and other settings working with children. You may share it with colleagues. Share the student and parent guides, not this page, with students and families.